

Content Ratings and Safety Filters

Content rating systems provide standardized categories to **classify media by age suitability and content**. Around the world, film and game ratings (like the US **MPA/MPAA** film ratings, the **ESRB** in North America for games, or Europe's **PEGI** for games) help **audiences and creators understand what age group a character or story is appropriate for and why**. These systems use **age brackets** (e.g. "13+") and **content descriptors** (for violence, language, etc.) to label content ¹ ². The goal of a unified safety schema for fictional characters is to **capture these standard categories in a clear, consistent way** – allowing creators, curators, and platforms to **assess "Can I responsibly use this character in my context?"** based on multiple rating standards. Below we outline key facets of this schema:

Target Audience

This section identifies **who the content is intended for** in terms of age and audience type:

- **Age Range:** The recommended age suitability, given as a range or minimum age. For example, a character might be marked "**7-12**" or "**16+**" or "**Adults Only**" depending on content. Traditional ratings map to such ages: e.g. ESRB "Teen" means *13 and up* ³, **Mature 17+** is for *ages 17 and up* ⁴, and **PEGI 16** or **18** indicate adult-level content in Europe ⁵ ⁶. This field makes it clear if the character is **kid-friendly, teen-appropriate, or adults-only**.
- **Demographics:** Additional notes about the target audience's characteristics or interests, if relevant. For instance, a character could be designed for an *educational STEM-focused audience* or *fans of a specific cultural folklore*. This is optional and helps clarify context (e.g. "*suitable for young children, educational content*" or "*aimed at adult horror enthusiasts*").
- **Tone Alignment:** Describes the overall **tone and mood** of the character's content – for example **lighthearted, neutral, or gritty**. Tone can affect how content is perceived; a **whimsical or cartoonish presentation** can make mild fantasy violence feel more benign ⁷, whereas a **dark, gritty tone** might amplify the impact of similar actions. By tagging tone, one can distinguish a *lighthearted comedic* character from a *grim, realistic* one, even if both have some violence or conflict.

Appropriateness

This section breaks down **content elements and their intensity**. It specifies what kind of potentially sensitive content is present and to what degree, helping align with standard content descriptors:

- **Violence Level:** *None, Cartoon/Fantasy, Realistic, or Extreme*. This rates the intensity of violent content. **None** means no violence at all. **Cartoon or mild fantasy violence** refers to *non-realistic, often consequence-free conflicts* (e.g. slapstick or fights where no one is seriously hurt) – such content is generally allowed in lower age ratings ⁸. For instance, "*cartoon violence*" where characters bounce back unharmed is treated mildly by rating boards ⁸. **Realistic violence** involves more true-to-life harm (characters can be injured or blood is shown), often pushing a rating to teen levels or higher ⁹ ⁴. **Extreme violence** indicates very graphic, intense violence – e.g. gore, dismemberment, or violence against the defenseless – which is usually restricted to adult audiences

- ⁶ ¹⁰ . (For example, **ESRB “Adults Only 18+”** may include *prolonged scenes of intense violence* ¹⁰ , and **PEGI 18** allows “gross violence” such as graphic killings or torture ⁶ .)
- **Sexuality Level:** *None*, *Implied/Mild*, or *Explicit*. This denotes sexual content. **None** means no sexual themes. **Implied or mild sexual content** includes *suggestive themes, innuendo or off-screen references* – for example, *romantic scenes or joking references but no explicit act shown*. Many teen-rated works allow brief romance or implied intimacy (e.g. **PEGI 12** permits *innuendo or implied sexual activity, but nothing explicit* ¹¹). **Explicit sexual content** means *actual depictions of sexual acts or nudity*. This is generally for mature audiences only. Rating boards distinguish **non-explicit vs. explicit** sexual content: ESRB’s “*Sexual Content*” descriptor means **non-explicit** sexual behavior ¹² , whereas “*Strong Sexual Content*” means **explicit or frequent** sexual acts or nudity ¹³ . A character marked “explicit” in sexuality would likely be rated adults-only (e.g. a **PEGI 18** game may show sexual activity with visible genitals ¹⁴).
 - **Language Level:** *Clean*, *Mild*, *Strong*, or *Explicit*. This gauges the severity of profanity or coarse language. **Clean** means essentially no profanity (or extremely minor exclamations). **Mild** language might include the occasional **infrequent, low-tier swear word** or insult – content that *stops short of the strongest profanity*. For example, **ESRB “Language”** means *mild to moderate profanity* ¹⁵ , and **PEGI 12** allows some swearing but **no usage of the harsher sexual expletives** like the “F-word” ¹⁶ . **Strong** language indicates frequent use of harsh profanity (the kinds of words that typically result in a teen/mature rating). For instance, a game or film with repeated use of the F-word or similar would be flagged for older teens or adults; ESRB’s “*Strong Language*” tag means **explicit and/or frequent profanity** is present ¹⁷ . **Explicit (Extreme) language** would be reserved for pervasive profanity or highly offensive slurs – the kind of language usage that might push a film from PG-13 to R. (Notably, the MPAA film ratings famously allow *at most one non-sexual use of the F-word in a PG-13*; more than one, or usage in a sexual context, will “*usually incur an R rating*” ¹⁸ .) In summary, this category notes if the character’s dialogue includes no bad words, a few mild ones, or heavy profanity.
 - **Cultural Sensitivity:** Any **tags or warnings for culturally sensitive content** that might not be covered by the above. This includes things like **racial or ethnic slurs, stereotypes, hate speech, or other potentially offensive cultural elements**. Such content is generally handled very cautiously by rating systems – for example, PEGI has a specific “*Discrimination*” content descriptor which is **only used for adult-rated content**, since any material that encourages hatred (e.g. ethnic/religious slurs or extreme stereotyping) automatically warrants a **PEGI 18** rating ¹⁹ . In this schema, one would flag if the character’s portrayal or story includes sensitive cultural issues (for example, “*contains racial slurs*”, “*depicts religious themes that may offend*”, or “*features historical prejudices*”). This warns curators or users to handle or present the character with appropriate care (or avoid certain contexts altogether).

Content Rating

This field links the character to **official content rating labels** from various standard systems. It allows **multi-system tagging** – for example, one could specify a rating in **ESRB terms** and in **PEGI terms**, etc., to cover different regions or platforms. Each entry in this field has a **rating system name** (e.g. *ESRB*, *PEGI*, *MPA/MPAA*, or a custom system) and the **rating** within that system (e.g. “*T for Teen*”, “*PEGI 12*”, “*PG-13*”). Optional **notes** can clarify edge cases or specific reasons for the rating.

- **ESRB (Entertainment Software Rating Board, North America):** Uses categories like **E (Everyone)**, **T (Teen 13+)**, **M (Mature 17+)**, **AO (Adults Only 18+)**, etc. For example, a character with moderate violence and mild language might be rated “**T – Teen**” (suitable for 13+; may include violence or

crude humor and infrequent strong language ²⁰). A character with intense realistic violence or sexual content would be “**M – Mature 17+**” (17 and up, can include intense violence, blood/gore, sexual content, and strong language ⁴). Extreme cases (graphic sexual content or extreme violence) fall under “**AO – Adults Only 18+**”, which is rarely used except for very mature games ¹⁰ .

- **PEGI (Pan-European Game Information, Europe):** Uses **age labels** 3, 7, 12, 16, 18, each with content descriptors. For instance, **PEGI 12** indicates suitable for 12 and up – it can feature *non-realistic or moderate violence toward fantasy characters and mild bad language*, but nothing too graphic ⁹ ¹⁶ . **PEGI 16** means the content is akin to what is acceptable for ages 16+ (violence or sexual activity that looks realistic, more extreme language, presence of tobacco/alcohol or drug use) ⁵ . **PEGI 18** is an adult-only rating, for games with *gross realistic violence, glamorization of drugs, or explicit sexual content* ⁶ . Multiple PEGI content descriptors (violence, sex, drugs, bad language, fear, etc.) may accompany the age label to explain why the game/character got that rating. In this schema you can list the PEGI rating and any pertinent content tags.
- **MPA Film Ratings (formerly MPAA, United States):** The film rating system uses **G, PG, PG-13, R, NC-17** to categorize movies by suitability. For example, a character suitable for all ages would be “**G – General Audiences**” (no violence, no profanity, etc.), whereas one fitting a “**PG-13**” context may involve intense action violence or mild sexual material but **not** extreme gore or explicit sex ² . A character marked “**R – Restricted (17+)**” could have strong realistic violence, heavy language, or sexual content; R is roughly parallel to a “Mature” category (and indeed many video games rated M would likely be R if films). **NC-17** or “Adult Only” for film would be reserved for explicit content exceeding even R (graphic sexuality or extreme violence). In applying this schema, one might tag a horror-themed character as “Rated R” if they involve graphic horror violence and strong language. (Note: the MPA ratings also consider specific rules – e.g., using the F-word more than once tends to push a film from PG-13 to R ¹⁸ , and any sexually explicit scenes or very graphic violence will also require an R or NC-17.)
- **Other or Custom Systems:** The schema is extensible. Creators can include ratings from other regional boards (like **BBFC 15** in the UK, **USK 16** in Germany, etc., if relevant) or **custom content codes** used by a particular platform/community. The idea is to support a unified profile that can list **equivalent ratings across multiple systems** so that anyone reviewing the character can understand its placement in their local rating framework. For example, one could list **ESRB: M (17+), PEGI: 18, MPA: R**, which all consistently signal a mature content level in different regions.

Having multi-system tags is useful for global distribution – it ensures the character’s content level is clear in terms of **international standards**. (Initiatives like the **IARC** – International Age Rating Coalition – already streamline generating region-appropriate ratings based on one questionnaire ²¹ ²² , reflecting the common core criteria across ESRB, PEGI, etc.)

Deployment Contexts

Deployment contexts describe *where and how this character can be safely used or presented* given their content rating. In other words, this outlines the **appropriate media or audience contexts** for the character. Examples might include:

- “**Kids’ RPG**” or **Children’s Platform**: Indicates the character is suitable for child-friendly content (must be rated E or equivalent). If a character’s profile says it can appear in a *kids’ role-playing game*, that implies it has no mature content – likely *no violence or only cartoon mischief, no profanity, no*

sexual material. Curators would thus confidently include this character in educational games, children's story apps, or Saturday morning cartoons.

- **“Teen Story” or General Mainstream:** Means the character is appropriate for teen audiences and general-purpose use. For instance, a hero marked for *“general purpose”* might be fine in a wide range of contexts such as PG-13 movies, YA novels, or mainstream comics – some action or light romance is fine, but nothing overtly adult-only.
- **“Adult Webcomic” or Mature-audience Context:** This suggests the character should **only appear in explicitly mature contexts** (e.g. an R-rated film, an adult graphic novel, a late-night horror game). If a character has significant gore, sexual themes, or other adult content, the deployment context would note that it's *limited to adult audiences* or a specific mature setting (like *“18+ horror webcomic”*).

Specifying deployment contexts helps **content creators and platforms enforce appropriate placement**. For example, a platform could automatically prevent a character rated for mature deployment from showing up in a children's game. It's essentially a quick answer to *“Where can I responsibly use this character?”* – aligning the character's content rating with the intended venue or audience.

Safety Warnings

Safety warnings are **explicit content flags** that call out particularly sensitive or triggering material associated with the character. They supplement the broad content categories with **specific cautionary details**. These warnings ensure that anyone using or encountering the character is forewarned about elements that might require discretion or content moderation. Examples include:

- **Explicit Violence/Gore Warnings:** e.g. *“Contains horror-themed gore and body horror.”* If a character's story involves disturbing transformations or graphic injury (for instance, a **body-morphing horror** element where human anatomy is grotesquely altered), this would be flagged. As an example, PEGI's horror descriptor notes that at the 16+ level there may be *“intense and sustained horror sequences with dismembered bodies”* ²³ – which a safety warning might summarize as *“graphic gore and body horror present.”*
- **Sexual Violence or Abuse Warnings:** e.g. *“Includes sexual violence”* or *“backstory involves rape/abuse”*. This is critical to flag explicitly, as it's a highly sensitive content type. Rating boards like ESRB and PEGI treat sexual violence as a distinct category – any depiction of rape or sexual coercion is always adult-rated and typically comes with a content warning ²⁴. In a character sheet, a note such as *“Warning: character's storyline includes sexual assault”* lets users decide if they're comfortable with that content in their project.
- **Self-Harm, Substance Abuse, or Other Sensitive Themes:** If applicable, warnings might include statements like *“themes of self-harm,” “suicidal ideation,” “substance addiction,”* etc. While rating systems often incorporate these into descriptors (e.g. drug use is noted by ESRB/PEGI with labels ²⁵), a custom warning ensures the specific trigger is visible. For cultural or ethical sensitivities, one might see warnings such as *“contains religious blasphemy”* or *“depicts discrimination/hate speech”* (the latter would overlap with the Cultural Sensitivity tag and, as noted, would be adult-restricted content ¹⁹).

These safety warnings **go beyond the one-word content labels** to give a short description of the exact issue. They are especially useful for curators or community moderators who need to quickly scan for red-flag content, and for audience members who appreciate heads-up about potentially disturbing material. In practice, they function like the detailed *content advisories* you often see in film rating info (“Rated R for

strong bloody violence and language” or “Trigger warning: depiction of self-harm”). By including them, we ensure that the schema doesn’t just classify content broadly, but also **communicates specific caution areas** to anyone handling the character.

In summary, a unified content rating and safety profile for a character would combine the above fields to give a comprehensive picture of appropriateness. It specifies the **target age and tone**, the levels of **violence, sexuality, language, etc.**, the official **rating labels from multiple systems**, where the character is **allowed to appear**, and any **special warnings**. This allows creators and platforms to **align characters with the right projects and audiences**. A curator can check this profile and immediately know, for example, that a given character is *PG-13/PEGI 12 level, with mild language and fantasy violence, suitable for a teen adventure game, but not to be used in a young kids’ app*. Adopting such a schema across models and content libraries makes it easier to maintain consistency and **uphold safety standards** in storytelling and interactive media. ²⁶ ¹⁶

Sources:

1. ESRB – *Entertainment Software Rating Board* guidelines (age categories and content descriptors) ⁴
¹⁰ ¹² ¹⁷
2. PEGI – *Pan European Game Information* ratings and content descriptors ⁸ ¹⁶ ⁵ ⁶
3. MPA (MPAA) – Film rating system (guidelines for violence, language, etc. in G/PG/PG-13/R films) ²
¹⁸
4. International Age Rating Coalition – Unified rating questionnaire used to map multiple systems ²⁷
²² (demonstrates similar criteria across ESRB, PEGI, etc.)
5. AskAboutGames – *Content Descriptors Explained* (PEGI examples for violence, language, sex, discrimination, horror) ⁹ ¹¹

¹ ²⁰ ²¹ ²² ²⁶ ²⁷ IARC Ratings Guide | International Age Rating Coalition

<https://www.globalratings.com/ratingsguide.aspx>

² ¹⁸ Motion Picture Association film rating system - Wikipedia

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Motion_Picture_Association_film_rating_system

³ ⁴ ¹⁰ ¹² ¹³ ¹⁵ ¹⁷ ²⁴ ESRB Ratings Guides, Categories, Content Descriptors

<https://www.esrb.org/ratings-guide/>

⁵ ⁶ ⁷ What do the labels mean? | Pegi Public Site

<https://pegi.info/what-do-the-labels-mean>

⁸ ⁹ ¹¹ ¹⁴ ¹⁶ ¹⁹ ²³ ²⁵ Content descriptors - Ask About Games

<https://askaboutgames.com/need-to-know/what-are-content-descriptors>